



A new kind of cavalry

The mechanization of the cavalry took place at different times across the world. Britain led the way in mechanization after a series of exercises on Salisbury Plain in the late 1920s, which showed the overwhelming advantages of a fully mechanized force—infantry in trucks, artillery towed by tracked or wheeled vehicles, tanks, and tracked scouting carriers.

In 1928, the first British cavalry regiments were mechanized. The Great Depression and the consequent reduced budgets for the military—rather than the innate conservatism of the cavalry regiments—meant it took another 10 years before the remaining cavalry regiments in Britain were mechanized. The British War Office tried to transfer the *élan* of the cavalry into the new

mechanized roles, with cavalry regiments being used for scouting, reconnaissance, intelligence gathering, and screening advances and retreats.

Memoirs, magazines, and newspapers of the time were full of the sense of loss many in the cavalry felt—for centuries of tradition, for their horses, and for sharp uniforms being replaced with drab coveralls. Lt. Col. C. E. Morgan wrote in a poem: “I’ve spent my life with ‘orses and I loved the work and toil/But I can’t stand these new fledged beasts that live on gas and oil.”

British troopers of the Queen's Bays cavalry regiment are shown a Vickers Light Tank in trials in Dorset, UK in the 1930s.